Unit 8 — Erste Mediation: A German E-mail

Track G+M · Klasse 7 · Niveau G/M

Learning objectives I

- *I can explain the gist of a short German message in three or four English sentences for a clear addressee and purpose.*
- *I can choose what to keep, paraphrase, or leave out depending on what the addressee needs to know.*
- *I can use simple reporting verbs (says, explains, asks, advises) instead of literal translation.*

Lead-in I

Aisha's mother forwarded an e-mail from the school. The e-mail was in German. Aisha needed to explain it to her cousin in Manchester before the weekend, because the school trip date had moved. The e-mail had four paragraphs and one list. Aisha did not need to translate them. She only had to tell her cousin what to put in his diary.

Vocabulary I

- sagen
- erklären
- erwähnen
- empfehlen / raten

- fragen
- bitten
- antworten

Reading I

What mediation is
Mediation is moving meaning from one language to another **for someone**. The ”for someone” is the trick. The receiver tells you what to keep, what to paraphrase, and what to drop.
A useful frame:

1. *Who is reading this?*
2. *What do they need to do, decide, or know?*
3. *What is the smallest amount of information that gets them there?*

Reading II

Source text — *E-Mail von der Schule*
Liebe Eltern, der ursprünglich für den 14. Juni geplante Wandertag wird auf den 21. Juni verschoben. Treffpunkt bleibt der Hauptbahnhof, jedoch 15 Minuten früher als ursprünglich angegeben. Wer den Zug um 7:45 Uhr verpasst, kann an der Wanderung leider nicht mehr teilnehmen. Bitte denken Sie daran, dass festes Schuhwerk und eine Regenjacke verpflichtend sind. Mit freundlichen Grüßen, die school administration (Schulleitung).

Mediation in English — three sentences
”Hi Tom, the school hike has been moved from June 14 to June 21. We meet at the main station fifteen minutes earlier — at 7:30. If you miss the train, you can’t come, so don’t forget good shoes

Reading III

and a rain jacket.”
Notice:

- **Greeting matches the addressee** (*Hi Tom*, not *Dear Parents*).
- **Date is converted** (German ”21. Juni” → English ”June 21”).
- **Salutation is dropped** (”Mit freundlichen Grüßen, die school administration (Schulleitung)” is not useful for Tom).
- **Information is reordered** for what Tom needs to do.

Reading IV

Useful reporting verbs

German cue	English
sagen	to say (that)
erklären	to explain (that)

German cue	English
erwähnen	to mention (that)
empfehlen / raten	to advise (someone to)

Reading V

German cue	English
fragen	to ask (whether/where/why)
bitten	to ask (someone to)

German cue	English
antworten	to answer (that)

No subjunctive needed at Klasse 7. *He says that he is tired.* is fine. The Konjunktiv I (*er sagt, dass er müde sei*) is not required in English mediation at this level.

Practise I

Niveau G — controlled
A. Drop or keep? Read the sentence and decide whether the information is *essential*, *non-essential*, or *to be paraphrased* when mediating to a friend in Manchester.

1. ”Treffpunkt bleibt der Hauptbahnhof, jedoch 15 Minuten früher.”
2. ”Mit freundlichen Grüßen, die school administration (Schulleitung).”
3. ”Bitte denken Sie daran, dass festes Schuhwerk verpflichtend ist.”
4. ”Liebe Eltern,”

Practise II

B. Reporting-verb match.

German verb	English
1. erklären	a. to ask
2. fragen	b. to advise

German verb	English
3. raten	c. to explain

Practise III

Niveau M — productive
C. Mini-mediation. Read the German source line and write **one** English sentence for an English-speaking peer.

5. ”Mama hat angerufen und gesagt, sie kommt zehn Minuten später.” → ___
6. ”Bitte mach mein Handy aus, wenn du es findest.” → ___
7. ”Der Lehrer fragt, ob du heute zur Hausaufgabenhilfe kommst.” → ___

Your turn I

mediation (”Mediation”) task — *The Forwarded Message*. Your German cousin forwards you a real-looking e-mail (provided on the slide). Your job: write a short English message (60–120 words depending on Niveau) to your English-speaking friend explaining what to do.
Three rules:

1. *Greeting and tone match your friend, not the original sender.*
2. *Drop ceremony lines. Keep dates, times, places, actions.*
3. *Use at least one reporting structure (says, asks, advises, explains).*

Your turn II

Sample student response (Niveau M, 110 words)
Hi Jordan, my cousin's school just sent a notice and I'm forwarding the gist. The class trip on June 14 has been moved to June 21. The teacher asks everyone to meet at the main station at 7:30 instead of 7:45. She mentions that anyone who misses the train can't come on the trip. She also advises us to bring good walking shoes and a rain jacket — apparently the forecast is unstable. Tell your mum so she doesn't drive to the station on the wrong day. Talk later! — Aisha.

Reflect I

- I can explain the gist of a German message in English with a clear addressee.
- I can drop ceremony lines and keep what the receiver needs.
- I can use *says / explains / asks / advises* instead of literal translation.

Further reading / listening I

- Goethe-Institut — Beispiel-Aufgaben language mediation (Sprachmittlung) Englisch (Sek I). https://www.goethe.de
- BBC Bitesize — *Reported speech*. https://www.bbc.co.uk/bitesize/topics/zhfygdm
- Landesbildungsserver BW — mediation (”Mediation”)-Beispielaufgaben. https://www.schule-bw.de